

Ajai Chowdhry comes from a patriotic family where art and music were an integral part of life. Before India's partition in 1947, Ajai's father worked as a flourishing criminal lawyer in what is now known as Pakistan. As a president of the Congress at the then Abbotabad, he was deeply involved in the Indian freedom movement and came in touch with Father of the Nation Mahatma Gandhi and Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan, who was commonly known as Frontier Gandhi.

Ajai's parents shifted from Abbotabad in Pakistan to India along with their six children after the partition. "They came to India in difficult circumstances with nothing in hand, only the children on a train, which was pretty much the last train out of Pakistan. I was told that my parents got separated from my siblings into different bogeys and they had no idea what was happening to their children. On the way, my grandmother died. Finally, they landed in Delhi and started living in an old dirty house that belonged to a Muslim family that had left India. After a while, they moved to a refugee camp," Ajai tells while narrating the post-partition crisis faced by his family.

Immediately after shifting to India, Ajai's father got a job related to integration of the princely states after Independence and shifted to Mount Abu in Rajasthan. Ajai recalls, "My family moved to a fantastic place on the bank of beautiful Nakki Lake and their life changed. They all settled down in Mount Abu and I was born there in 1950. I have never been to Mount Abu since then; I've just been hearing beautiful stories about how fantastic that home was. Someday, I shall visit that home. It's on my bucket list."

Remembering the early years

In 1955, Ajai's father joined the administrative service as an IAS

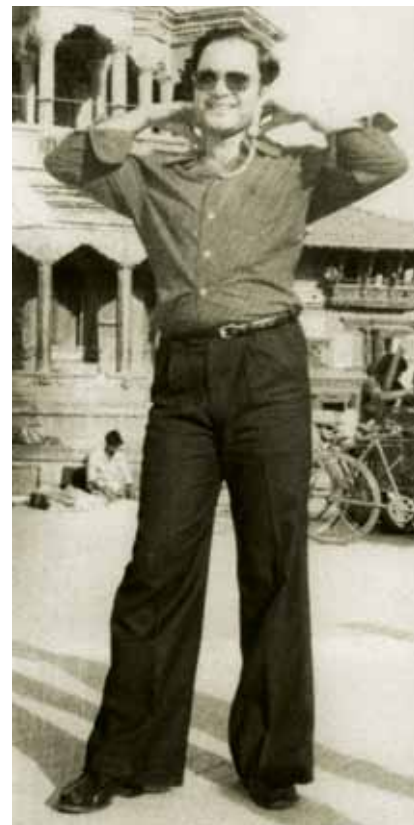
"I grew up in a very different family environment. My parents were fond of art and music. My father, Jai Krishna Chowdhry Habeeb, was a reasonably known Urdu poet. My sister used to put the ghazals that he wrote to tune. We would have mushairas at home. I was introduced to classical music at a young age during our stay in Rewa. That place was near Maihar. Therefore, my father used to take us to visit Maihar Gharana and listen to music at each possible opportunity. I also got the opportunity to listen to the famous sarod maestro Allauddin Khan's music. Because of my upbringing in such a musical environment, I also got fond of music. I tried my hand at tabla, but it just didn't work out. Then I learned something interesting. I learned how to play tabla by mouth. I remember doing performances on stage with my sister. She would sing and I would play tabla with my mouth." — **Ajai Chowdhry**

officer. He says, "It took the entire family on a different journey as my father chose a state called Vindhya Pradesh for his first posting. Later, that place was merged with Madhya Bharat and Bhopal to form Madhya Pradesh. As an IAS officer, my father had to move from one place to another in Vindhya Pradesh. Most of those small places were underdeveloped. The first posting was to a small place called Shahdol that did not even have tap water."

From Shahdol, Ajai's family moved to Nowgong. Life was better there as the family started staying in a huge British-era residence with a beautiful orchard. The house had a swimming pool and tennis court. Ajai started learning those sports there only. However, shortly thereafter, his father was posted to Rewa near Allahabad. Ajai began his schooling there in a Hindi-medium school run by the queen of Rewa, Praveen Kumari.

Ajai's life was quite eventful at Rewa. He used to visit the maharaja's palace to see his pet, Mohan, a white tiger. The maharaja also had a collection of fancy cars. Ajai was quite fascinated by them. He still remembers that the bonnet of a car was adorned with cut diamonds.

While remembering his unique childhood experiences, Ajai tells the story of his pet, which was a tiger cub. "We used to play with the cub and sometimes got scratched. But he didn't last long, because those days there was the concept of spraying DDT, which was very dangerous for animals as they used to lick it



Ajai Chowdhry in Dev Anand style

unknowingly and die. Exactly the same happened to that poor fellow. I was so upset that my father got it stuffed and gave it to me as a gift to keep it in my room."

Ajai developed a fondness for pets since then. Later, he got an Alsatian as a pet. To date, Ajai keeps pet dogs at home.

After staying a few years in Rewa, his father retired and the family shifted to Jabalpur. He was admitted to the Christ Church School, Jabalpur, for his formal education.

School days were a golden time